

SAVASANA

Also known as Corpse pose, Savasana is the final relaxation pose often practiced for 5–15 minutes at the end of yoga classes. It is also used for meditative practices, such as yoga nidra. While there is still more research to be done, Savasana has been used clinically for its relaxation benefits.



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WHAT IS SAVASANA AND WHAT ARE ITS BENEFITS?

Savasana is practiced lying flat on your back with your legs and arms relaxed symmetrically, palms face up. It can also be used for relaxation and as a meditation posture if sitting is uncomfortable or you are not well. Its many benefits include:

- activating the parasympathetic nervous system (PNS) and all the profound benefits of this relaxation response, including lowering blood pressure and slowing heart rate
- teaching muscles to relax effectively
- increasing heart rate variability, representing resilience.

6

weekly sessions
of yoga nidra
improved stress,
muscle tension,
and self-care.



WHAT IS PROGRESSIVE MUSCLE RELAXATION?

Progressive muscle relaxation (PMR) involves squeezing and then releasing your muscles, often sequentially from head to toe, while in Savasana. This encourages neuromuscular connection, giving the body-mind clear examples of tension and release, which helps the body relax physically. Immediately after your muscle fibers contract, they have the capacity to lengthen or relax even more.



WHY IS THERE OFTEN A LONGER, GUIDED SAVASANA AT THE END OF CLASS?

This is a mindfulness practice called yoga nidra. Nidra means sleep, so think of it as a “yoga nap.” A general intention of the practice is to remain alert to allow observation of the physiological effects of each stage of sleep. It is usually practiced in Savasana for 15–30 minutes and in small studies has shown promising results for improving sleep, decreasing depression, and managing chronic pain.